

CORE FORMULA

Context + relevance + one bounded advice question + autonomy release + uptake. -> I'm choosing how to open this stakeholder update. You're good at making things clear fast, so what would you lead with? -> I'm deciding whether to raise this in the meeting or one-to-one. You've handled similar dynamics, so what would you watch for? -> I'm rewriting this message. Could I ask your first impression on the tone? One sentence is enough. -> You know this client better than I do. What's one mistake I should avoid on the first call?

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Name one specific decision, give a light reason their judgement helps, ask a single answerable question, then stop and let them choose whether and how much to answer.

BEST FOR

- Asking mentors, colleagues, friends or experienced peers for a bounded view
- Building rapport with someone whose judgement you genuinely respect
- Inviting a person to contribute without asking them to take over
- Stakeholder conversations where you need judgement before action
- Networking messages that should feel respectful rather than extractive
- Learning a decision criterion, a pitfall or a first step
- Giving status to someone without resorting to generic praise
- Turning vague admiration into a practical, specific conversation

PHRASE BANK

Bounded openers · General advice request

- "Could I ask your advice on one part of this?"
- "What would you look at first here?"
- "What's one thing you'd avoid if you were in my position?"
- "What would you want to know before deciding?"
- "What's the simplest next step you'd test?"
- "What's one factor you'd weigh before deciding?"

Respectful relevance · Naming why their view helps

- "You've handled this kind of situation before."
- "You have a good read on this audience."
- "You tend to spot the risk I miss."
- "You know the practical side better than I do."
- "Your judgement on tone is usually sharp."
- "You've seen how that team actually operates."

Work and decisions · Meeting, email, stakeholder

- "Could I get your advice on the framing before I send this?"
- "What would you prioritise in the first version?"
- "What would make this easier for the team to act on?"
- "Where do you think this is too vague?"
- "What would be the cleanest way to raise this?"
- "Does this land, or am I burying the ask?"

Social and personal · Friends, delicate conversations

- "Can I ask your advice on how to approach this conversation?"
- "You know them better than I do. What should I be careful with?"
- "What would be a kind way to bring this up?"
- "What would you do first, if you were trying not to make it weird?"
- "What's one way I could raise this without sounding accusatory?"
- "I'm not asking you to carry the whole thing, just how to start it."

Digital and low-friction · Text, DM, async

- "No need for a long reply. What's your quick instinct?"
- "A one-line reaction would help, if you have it."
- "Could you mark the one part that feels off?"
- "Reply with the main risk you see, if anything jumps out."
- "If you have one quick pointer on where to start, I'd appreciate it. No pressure."
- "Even a thumbs up or a 'nope' on this would help."

Busy or senior person · Low-burden asks

- "I know you're stretched, so a quick pointer is enough."
- "This may be too small for your time. If so, no problem."
- "Could I ask for a 30-second steer rather than a full review?"
- "What's the one question I should answer before taking this further?"
- "Could I ask what you'd check on this proposal before I send it?"
- "Just the headline of what you'd change is plenty."

After they answer · Closing the loop, keeping ownership

- "That gives me a clearer first step."
- "The useful bit I'm taking is to check the expectation first."
- "I hadn't separated those two risks. Thank you."
- "I'll try that and keep the scope small."
- "Thanks. I won't make you own the decision, but this helps."
- "That's useful. I was only looking at the title, so I'll ask that before I decide."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "Can I pick your brain?" Vague, extractive and open-ended, so the person cannot tell the size of the request.

Better: "Could I ask your advice on this client email?" Clearer, but still does not specify the kind of advice or the effort needed.

Best: "Could I ask your advice on the opening line of this client email? You know this client well, and a quick instinct is enough." Specific scope, real relevance, low effort and an easy out.

2. Weak: "What should I do?" Dumps ownership of the decision onto them.

Better: "What would you do in my situation?" More personal, but still broad.

Best: "What's one factor you'd weigh before deciding?" Asks for judgement without outsourcing the decision.

3. Weak: "You're a genius at this, so please tell me exactly how to handle it." Over-flattery plus a heavy burden.

Better: "You have good judgement here. What do you think?" Respectful, but still broad.

Best: "You have a good read on this audience. What tone would you avoid in the first paragraph?" Specific, respectful and answerable.

DECISION TREE

If Do I genuinely want their advice, not validation or rescue?

If no, use appreciation, a clean request or direct disclosure instead of an advice request.

If Is the question narrow enough for a short answer?

If no, shrink it to one decision, risk, first step, phrase, criterion or warning.

"What's one thing you'd check before I decide?"

If Is this the right person, and a fair ask?

If no, do your own groundwork first or ask someone more appropriate.

If Could the ask feel like pressure or unpaid labour?

If yes, add scope, a time limit, payment, reciprocity or an easy decline.

"A quick instinct is enough, and no pressure if now isn't a good time."

If Do I actually need advice, or action?

If action, switch to a clean or specific request rather than dressing it up as advice.

If They've answered. Now what?

Reflect the useful point, thank them specifically, keep ownership of the decision, and close the loop later if the relationship warrants it.

"The part I'm taking is to check the expectation first. Thank you."

SCENARIOS

Workplace mentor

Ask for one lens, not a full review, and accept a brief answer as complete. — "Could I ask for a 30-second steer on this proposal? What would you check before I send it?"

Peer with practical experience

Ask for a warning, not a solution, since they have hit this before. — "You ran into this last quarter. What's one trap I should avoid?"

Digital networking with a new contact

Make the scope tiny and explicit, and do not ask for a roadmap or referral. — "I know this is a small ask from a new contact. If you have one quick pointer on where to start, I'd appreciate it. No pressure."

Friend or personal conversation

Ask without turning the friend into a therapist; release the ask if they seem stretched. — "Can I ask your advice on how to raise this kindly? I'm not asking you to carry the whole thing."

Conflict or delicate feedback

Ask for one phrasing before the hard conversation rather than the whole plan. — "What's one way I could bring this up without sounding accusatory?"

After advice is given

Name the specific piece you're taking so they can see it landed. — "The part I'm taking is to check the expectation before I propose a solution. That's useful."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- You do not plan to listen to or consider the answer
- The person is overloaded, grieving, in crisis, under pressure or clearly not available
- You need a clean request for action, not advice
- You need permission to give advice rather than to ask for it (that is TC027)
- The topic needs licensed legal, medical, financial or safety-critical guidance beyond the person's role
- You are using a power imbalance to make refusal difficult
- The advice would require substantial unpaid labour and you have not offered scope, time, payment or a low-effort path
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the cue

Through the day, catch four moments where someone near you genuinely has relevant judgement (a work decision, a social conversation, a digital message, a busy or senior person). Note each one; ask nothing yet.

Day 2 — Narrow the target

For each of the four, write the single narrow advice target: one decision, risk, first step, criterion, phrasing or blind spot. Cut anything that would need a whole consultation to answer.

Day 3 — Name the relevance

For each, write one true, specific reason their judgement helps ("you've seen how that team operates"). Delete any line

that is really flattery rather than a real reason.

Day 4 — Build the full ask

Assemble each into the formula: context, relevance, one bounded question, an autonomy release, and a close-loop thanks. Say each version aloud once, and cut any that takes more than 20 seconds to explain.

Day 5 — Score and sharpen

Rate each version 1 to 5 (1 = vague or burdensome, 3 = clear but still broad, 5 = specific, respectful, low-pressure and answerable). Rewrite anything under 4.

Day 6 — Use one for real

Take your best-scoring ask into a real conversation. Ask it, then stop talking and leave the silence. Afterwards, note whether they gave a pointer easily or seemed pressured.

Day 7 — Close the loop

Go back to someone whose advice you used. Name the specific part you took and what you did with it. Notice how naming the useful piece changes the relationship.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Do I genuinely want advice, not validation or rescue?
- Have I narrowed the question to one part they could answer briefly?
- Is my reason for asking them true and specific, rather than flattery?
- Did I stop after asking, instead of adding pressure or preamble?
- Did I name the useful part and keep ownership of the decision?
- Am I using this to learn, not to extract labour, get an endorsement or make refusal awkward?